

Deciding who to tell first, after you've lost your job

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

You've just been let go and haven't told anyone yet. Part of you is afraid people will see you differently now, and staying quiet a little longer keeps that feeling at bay.

THE GOAL

Tell the right people, the right way, **before you have good news to soften it with**, so your network can start working for you.

CHECKLIST

Sitting with your phone, about to tell the first person you've lost your job.

- ☐ Call or message the one person you want with you right now, before anyone else, and tell them what happened in one short, plain sentence.
- ☐ If your voice shakes or your eyes sting while you say it, keep talking instead of stopping to apologize for it.
- ☐ In your notes app or on paper, list two or three people close to you who'd stay steady and act on what you tell them.
- ☐ Call or message the other close people you need to tell today, saying what happened, and when, in one short sentence.
- ☐ List one or two more people you know a little but haven't spoken to in a while, who might plausibly hear about job openings.
- ☐ Message each less-familiar contact what happened, in one plain sentence, then name one specific thing you want, like an introduction to someone at their company.
- ☐ **Send your message today anyway**, even though a direct, specific ask can feel like too much to ask for.
- ☐ If they answer with only sympathy or a vague offer to help, name the one specific thing you want, clearly, right then.
- ☐ After each conversation, add any name, company or lead they mentioned to one list on your phone, so you don't lose it.
- ☐ Set a number for today, like three to five people, and stop there rather than trying to reach everyone at once.
- ☐ Before you stop for today, pick one or two people you haven't reached yet to message first tomorrow.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Staying quiet doesn't spare you anything. The more your mind drifts back to it, **the more it wears on you**.
- 2 Looking shaken doesn't make you look weaker. People tend to rate someone else's vulnerability more kindly than they'd rate their own.
- 3 Being naturally outgoing has little to do with whether this works for you. **In a training program, the least outgoing people gained the most confidence and the best results.**

What waiting is costing you

DON'T

Staying quiet doesn't spare you anything. The more your mind drifts back to it, **the more it wears on you.**

The cost comes from how often it crosses your mind, not from how well you hide it, even when nobody's asking. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Looking shaken doesn't make you look weaker. People tend to rate someone else's vulnerability more kindly than they'd rate their own.

You tend to judge your own shaky moment far more harshly than someone watching you judges it. [Source 2](#)

Who helps you most

KNOW

In a large LinkedIn study, new connections who shared only a few mutual friends, or who you barely message, led to the most job moves, more than close, frequent contacts.

People close to you already know what you already know, while someone you barely keep up with moves in a different circle entirely. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

The person who helps most is compassionate, assertive, and hard to rattle.

People with those traits are the ones who keep you steady afterward, not just the ones who listen. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Reaching out feels riskier than it is. People underestimate how much a conversation partner likes them afterward.

The other person usually does show they like you, but you're too caught up in your own self-critical thoughts to register it. [Source 4](#)

Asking without stalling

SAY

Say the specific thing you want, out loud: 'If you hear of anything in this field, **I'd really appreciate you thinking of me.**'

Being asked outright puts real pressure on someone to help, but a hint lets them look past it without ever saying no. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Most people say yes more than you'd guess. In a set of studies, people guessed they'd need to ask about half again as many people as they did to get to yes.

You don't feel the mild pressure your direct ask puts on someone else, but they feel it clearly even if you never see it. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Being naturally outgoing has little to do with whether this works for you. **In a training program, the least outgoing people gained the most confidence and the best results.**

A structured program replaces relying on outgoing personality with steps anyone can follow, which matters more if you're not naturally outgoing. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. https://www.columbia.edu/~ms4992/Pubs/2024_Slepian_Current-Directions.pdf
2. <https://self-compassion.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/11/Bruk-et-al.-2021-You-and-I-Both-Self-Compassion-Reduces-Self%E2%80%93Other.pdf>
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Losing a job at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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